

His mother was an ardent Catholic and raised her children in that faith.

Elgar's musical education consisted of learning to play piano and violin from his father. As an adolescent, he aspired to study music in Germany, but his family could not afford to send him to Leipzig. Instead, he settled into a life as a musician, giving lessons, playing violin in provincial orchestras, and even organizing music at a local lunatic asylum.

Early life and influences

Elgar began composing from an early age. Although often regarded as a quintessentially English composer, he had no interest in his nation's folk music and was dismissive of its musical traditions. Instead, the models he sought to emulate were the great Germans such as Brahms, Schumann, and Wagner, whose works he had heard at concerts on day trips to London and later on vacations in Bavaria. Two of Elgar's early orchestral pieces were given public performances in 1883 and 1884, without making any impact. His private life also stalled, his engagement to a Worcester girl, Helen Weaver, terminated when she emigrated to New Zealand.

The person who saved Elgar from provincial frustration was Alice Roberts. Nine years older than the composer, she was the daughter of a major-general. In 1886, Elgar was employed to give her piano lessons. An unlikely love blossomed and the couple married in 1889, to the disgust of the haughty Roberts family, who were appalled by Elgar's inappropriate age, his lowly social status, and his Catholicism. The marriage had a profound